

METALLIC-CARTRIDGE PISTOLS (1853–70)

Pistol cartridges with metallic cases became practical through Lefauchaux's pin-fire design (see p.112). They were improved by Smith and Wesson's rim-fire cartridge (see pp.128–29) in 1860, and again by center-fire cartridges in the 1870s. In the US, manufacture of revolvers capable of using these cartridges was impeded by a patent taken out by Rollin White in 1859, later acquired by Smith and Wesson, which prevented others from making "bored-through" cylinders. These cylinders were bored all the way through for loading a cartridge from the rear, the cartridge case sealing the breech in the process. Once this patent expired in 1869, percussion revolvers were converted to utilize metallic cartridges, and new pistols were built to use them.

► COLT NAVY CONVERSION

Date 1861

Origin US

Barrel 7½in (19cm)

Caliber .36in

Colt replaced its angular 1851 Navy revolver (see p.88) with a new, streamlined version ten years later. This example has been converted to accept brass cartridges after the fashion of the Single Action Army (see p.95); many percussion revolvers were adapted in this way.



▲ LEFAUCHEUX PIN-FIRE REVOLVER

Date 1853

Origin France

Barrel 5¼in (13.5cm)

Caliber 12mm pin-fire

Eugène Lefauchaux produced a six-shot, double-action revolver in 12mm caliber for his father's 1835 pin-fire cartridge. This is a Cavalry model of 1853. An Army model, without a steadying spur, was also produced.

